

A Practical Study of PHILIPPIANS

THE GOAL OF CHRISTIAN LIVING “Important Keys to Successful, Fulfilled Living”

GOAL NUMBER FOUR – THE MIND OF CHRIST – PHILIPPIANS 2:1-11

The major goal of every Christian life is to be made like Jesus Christ. God will do what He needs to do to accomplish in our lives those objectives.

Nothing ever happens but what is a part of His purpose and plan.

We’ve seen it demonstrated in:

1. the LOVE of Christ,
2. the GLORY of Christ, and
3. we were courageous enough to deal with the subject of SUFFERING.

This is the area where so many Christians are deceived. Where so many are made bitter and resentful because they didn’t have enough faith to heal someone. Or because of something that happened in their lives and they feel like God doesn’t like them anymore.

We've really hit on something and our hope is that you'll take a long, long look at your own life and be sure that you have a proper understanding of what it is to be in the crucible—what it is to really suffer for Jesus' sake. When you learn that, remember that your life is going to end in suffering—physically—unless you just happen to go quickly by an accident or something of that source.

So the concept of suffering has to be forged before that time takes place, and Satan knows that.

So since we've hit one of his nerves, naturally it's not going to be comfortable for us to continue to pursue in these future studies the things that seem to disrupt his program that he's got going on worldwide.

Romans 8:17, 18

Since we are His children then, we will share His treasures. For all God gives His Son Jesus, is ours now too. But we must also share His suffering if we are to share His glory. Yet what we suffer now is nothing compared to the glory that He will give us later.

Erich Fromm has written some great books on love and the marriage relationship. He made this statement, which is very insightful:

If man has lost the capacity to suffer, he has also lost the capacity to change.
(source unknown)

If you have lost a capacity to suffer, you've also lost the capacity for change.

It's in the midst of this suffering that we put our money where our mouth is. Where we practice what we preach and we draw upon the resources that we've told everybody else about.

Bob Richards was an Olympic gold medal winner many years ago and his face appeared on Wheaties boxes—the breakfast of champions.

He wrote some books that told stories of incredible athletic prowess in impossible circumstances. You almost cried after every story if you wanted to be the very best.

One such story that really touched many deeply was the story of Babe Didrikson:

“You know about Babe Didrikson,” Bob Richards says, “who won two gold medals in the Olympic games. She was all-American in softball, basketball, horseback riding, tennis, golf, swimming and then cancer. At the height of her career, cancer. She called in her pastor the day before she died and said, ‘Pray a little harder. I’m getting a little closer.’ The pastor prayed and then left. I played golf with her husband and he told me the story himself of how she called him to her

bedside, took him by the hand and said ‘Honey, I hope you’ll find someone to love you as much as I have loved you.’ And then as he cried like a baby, she gripped his hand as tightly as she could and she said ‘Now honey, don’t take on so. While I’ve been in the hospital I’ve learned one thing. A moment of happiness is a lifetime and I’ve had a lot of happiness. I have had a lot of it.’ That’s courage. It goes to the heart of things; to stress the quality of life rather than just the quantity. To meet life’s greatest tragedy with a smile saying, ‘I’ve had a lot of great moments of happiness.’ This is courage.”

(source unknown)

There are times when the storm is heavy and things are pretty rough. But that’s where we put our money where our mouth is. That’s when we earn the right to have a ministry.

Now we turn from that to the other critical error, the area of Satan’s domination. That’s obviously why he’s so active. We’re dealing with his strategy.

There’s a great battle going on in our world. It sounds trite because we’ve heard the politicians and preachers tell us that. There’s a battle for the minds of men.

All you need to do is go into your local bookstore. Books have been replaced by the New Age. Every one of those books, as you walk down the aisle, all you see is “The Mind,” “The Mind,” “The Mind.” Satan knows. “If I can get the mind, I’ve got the heart, and I’ve got the life.”

It was Ralph Waldo Emerson who said:

What lies behind us and what lies before us are small matters compared to what lies within us.
(source unknown)

If we're going to grow and if we're going to mature in our Christian life, growth involves a mind change.

Glory involves mind conditioning. It's not just going to happen because we wish it so or we have some warm little emotional fuzzies. It's a mindset that creates it.

Before anything can be done to the mind, the love of Christ, the glory of Christ, the suffering of Christ must be understood. Then we begin to discover it is about the mind that he wants to talk to us about.

Now as we launch into this fabulous chapter, we talk first about the MIND. Then we're going to see it in living color, in four people's lives. We'll see it in:

1. JESUS,
2. PAUL, and
3. TIMOTHY, and
4. EPAPHRODITUS.

All incredible individuals. We call them GOD'S HALL OF FAME.

Every one of these men knew what it was to live with the love of Christ (the dominant theme), to live only for His glory, to be an individual who would be willing to suffer in order that Christ might be glorified.

Proverbs 23:7

For as he thinks within himself, so is he.

Proverbs 4:23

Watch over your heart with all diligence, for from it flows the springs of life.

Psalms 119:11

Thy word have I treasured in my heart, that I may not sin against Thee.

Psalms 1:2

But his delight is in the law of the Lord, and in His law does he meditate day and night.

How do we have a mind change? How do we begin to grow?

Satan knows it's by taking the divine revelation into the mind and to begin to think it. So that's why he organizes our day so we never have time to be in the Word. We never have time to communicate. He knows that he's hit the nerve.

If you don't know much about the Word of God, you are really open prey. Satan can then wreak havoc.

Earl Radmacher wrote a little book on what you can expect from the Holy Spirit. This is so insightful for this study:

(What to Expect From the Holy Spirit by Earl Radmacher)

So as I reflect deeply on the Word of God and I take it in, that becomes the raw material the Spirit of God uses to form Jesus Christ in me.

(source unknown)

As we chew on the Word of God, that's the raw material that the Spirit of God uses to form Jesus Christ in us. Now is that our ultimate goal? That's it!

(What to Expect From the Holy Spirit by Earl Radmacher)

And the formation of Jesus Christ in me is the Holy Spirit's grandest desire.

(source unknown)

That's what He wants. That's His ultimate goal.

Now listen to Jesus as He addresses the issue before we take up our verses.

Mark 7:21-23

For from within, out of the heart of men, proceed the evil thoughts and fornications, the thefts, the murders, the adulteries, the deeds of coveting and wickedness, as well as deceit, sensuality, envy, slander, pride and foolishness. All these evil things proceed from within and defile the man.

Proverbs 23:7

As a man thinks in his heart, so is he.

Tom Landry once made an interesting statement:

“Mental toughness leads to victory on the field.”
(source unknown)

He is talking Bible right there, whether he knew it or not. It's mental toughness that's going to lead to victory in the midst of suffering and difficulty in everything else, when we keep our focus on the Word of God.

Paul's in prison. Let's pick up at verse 1.

When you're in prison you have a lot of time to think about things. You have a lot of time when you're set aside for a while, to really mull over things. Paul's there.

If you want the deep yearnings of a man's heart while he was in prison, read Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *The Cost of Discipleship*. The man was in prison and finally hung by the Gestapo just before Germany was liberated by the US forces.

Verse 1—now we get the feeling. Here he is in prison.

v. 1 If there is therefore any encouragement in Christ, if there is any solace afforded by love, if there is any fellowship of the Spirit, if there is any affection and sympathy,

“If there is therefore any encouragement in Christ, if there is any solace afforded by love, if there is any fellowship of the Spirit, if there is any affection and sympathy,”

Paul's just saying “You know sitting here in prison all alone, you have some if's once in a while. I know there are.”

You could say here, “if there is—and I know there is.”

Paul's not depressed. He at least knows that it's the purpose of God that he's there. He's already told us in chapter 1 that it's going to turn out to the progress of the gospel. That doesn't change the living circumstances. So he hits you with four things. He needs:

1. ENCOURAGEMENT,
2. LOVE,
3. FELLOWSHIP, and
4. UNDERSTANDING.

Those are our greatest needs that we bring in those FOUR CONDITIONAL PHRASES.

Let's talk about those for just a second. Do you find it easy to speak words of encouragement to others?

1. "If there is therefore any encouragement in Christ..."

If you have your head together and you have to be thinking right when you say those kind of things to people that really brings healing to their lives. They bring encouragement. They can share insight and can be helpful.

Have you ever watched a ball player that's been encouraged by the coach and he goes back into the ballgame after he's just blown it? He might have fumbled the ball or something. He's the epitome of enthusiasm. He just goes crazy wanting to please his coach.

Why can't we do that with each other in the body of Christ? When the mind of Christ is controlling you, you're always

looking for the good things. You're always thinking "what can I say that will be an encouragement? How can I exhort? How can I encourage? How can I be an example?"

Mark Twain made this statement:

I can live for two months on one good compliment.
(source unknown)

Can't we all!

2. "if there is any solace afforded by love..."

"Anybody out there, love me, while I'm here in prison? I know you do. But you know, I just need to hear it once in a while. It brings a real solace to me and a real comfort."

3. "if there's any fellowship of the Spirit..."

"Are we in this together?"

1 John 1:3

That which we have seen and heard, declare we unto you,
that you also may have fellowship with us....

Joe Aldrich in *Secrets to Inner Beauty* says fellowship just isn't coffee and doughnuts. He says it this way:

(Secrets of Inner Beauty by Joe Aldrich)

It implies sharing and exchanging something. It is the deep spiritual community in Christ which believers share when they gather together as Christ's bride. Unfortunately, most of our social involvements have very little fellowship. We come together like marbles and we ricochet around the room. Our masks are firmly fixed, designed to complement our paint and our pillows. Often we long to reach out, to touch, and be touched, to intersect another life at a deep level. But the risk is too great.

(source unknown)

There are basically five levels of communication. Most of us stay on level number one rather than getting down to level number five, where real feelings come.

Jesus told the disciples just before Palm Sunday that He was going to Jerusalem to die. Do you know what their next statement was? James and John come up and say, "Can we sit on the right and on the left in the kingdom?"

Now you talk about a graphic illustration of a level 5 communication. "I'm going to Jerusalem to die!" And they come up and say "Can we sit on the right and on the left in your kingdom?"

They missed it. As believers we are so selfish! We are not sensitive enough to recognize there are some things going on at a pretty deep level and we waltz through life and walk over broken hearts and shattered dreams too many times. And we

miss it.

If there is any affection and sympathy.

Thy gentleness has made me great!

Here the apostle says:

“If there’s some of this, I sure would like it.”

Then that great verse—verse 2.

v. 2 make full my joy in order that you may be thinking the same thing, having the same love, united in spirit, thinking the one thing,

“make full my joy in order that you may be thinking the same thing, having the same love, united in spirit, thinking the one thing,”

What’s he focusing on? The MIND.

As believers this is our goal. The manifestation of the mind of Christ so that we begin to think the same things, that we have the same love for each other, that we’re united in spirit because we trust one another, that we’re thinking the same thing.

Now having said all of that, he points to a NEGATIVE in verses 3 and 4.

v. 3 doing nothing from selfish ambition or from empty conceit, but with humility of mind regarding one another as excelling themselves;

“doing nothing from selfish ambition or from empty conceit, but with humility of mind regarding one another as excelling themselves;”

When the flesh gets involved we think we're better than everybody else. When the Spirit is in control, we have deep appreciation for the gifts, the abilities, the talents that He's given.

Romans 8 uncovers it:

Romans 8:5-7

They that are after the flesh, do mind the things of the flesh. But they that are after the Spirit, the things of the Spirit. For to be carnally-minded is death, but to be spiritually-minded is life and peace. Because the carnal mind is enmity against God. It is not subject to the law of God, neither indeed can it be.

“with humility of mind” and

“regarding one another as excelling themselves.”

v. 4 not looking out each one for his own interests, but also each one the interests of others.

“not looking out each one on his own interests, but also each one on the interests of others.”

You see, sitting in the Upper Room they were thinking only of themselves and what they were going to get out of all the sacrifices they had made in following Jesus. So nobody learned the first lesson of being spiritually minded. That's to learn how to serve.

It's going to come hard but here it is.

What a classic passage. It's a command from the pen of the apostle.

v. 5 Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus,

“Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus,”

There's our KEY VERSE.

It is a COMMAND—stating it as succinctly as we know how.

Weymouth put it:

Let the very spirit which was in Christ Jesus be in you also.
(source unknown)

One writer said:

With longing all my heart is filled
That like Him I may be
As on the wondrous thought I dwell
That Christ lives in me.

(source unknown)

Why does he command them to have the mind of Christ?

Paul doesn't waste paper and if he is commanding them about the mind of Christ, then obviously there are some in Philippi who are carnal-minded.

There are some there who are creating some of the problem. In chapter 4 we're going to meet two of those women.

We are often able to tell in interpersonal relationships about which mind is controlling us.

When the Spirit of God is not dominating, then in the flesh we're going to have division, we're going to have strife, we're going to have a lot of things said that are forming in the flesh and coming out of that. Even among Christians.

If we are walking in the Spirit then we'd be one mind.

Isaiah 55:8-12

My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, declares the Lord, for as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways, and my thoughts than your thoughts. ...

The mind is Satan's mission field.

That's graphically depicted in 2 Corinthians. If he's doing his number right now, he's got you thinking about something else than this study. He has just nailed you. You've got your mind on something else.

Paul says:

2 Corinthians 4:4

In whom the God of this world has blinded the minds of them that believe not, lest the light of the glorious gospel of Christ, who is the image of God, should shine unto them.

Salvation is an act of God whereby conversion is the changing of a mind. Out of the changing of a mind comes the change of a direction.

We've been set free. As believers, we must learn to think God's thoughts if we're going to be fulfilled and happy.

Isaiah 26:3

Thou wilt keep him in perfect peace, whose mind is stayed on thee.

Now you're saying, "I want the mind of Christ. How do I have the mind of Christ?"

This is it! Our minds are changed by the Holy Spirit as He applies the Word of God to our life.

You cannot know the mind and the thoughts of God apart from being in the Word of God.

So many times we've said, "God, I don't understand this!"

But we also have to say, "I don't have to! I'm just going to trust You in the midst of it."

The hymn writer said it well:

*May the mind of Christ my Savior live in me from day to day
By his love and power controlled all I do and say.*

(source unknown)

That's a wonderful hymn but how do we put that into practice? We get in the Word! The only way we'll know His mind is to be in the Word.

Romans 12:1, 2—we all get hung up on the first verse: "Present our bodies a living sacrifice." But have you ever looked at verse 2?

Romans 12:2

Do not be conformed to this world, but be ye transformed [HOW?] by the renewing of your mind...

That's the INTAKE of the Word of God!

Ephesians 1:17, 18

That the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give unto you the spirit of wisdom and revelation and the knowledge of Him. The eyes of your understanding being enlightened, that you may know what is the hope of His calling...

1 Corinthians 2:16

For who has known the mind of the Lord, that he may instruct him, but we have the mind of Christ.

Hebrews 10:16

...I will put my laws in their hearts and in their minds will I write them.

Oh please God, do that for us.

May we have Your Word so that it's a staff of light filling our mind.

Ephesians 4:22-24

In reference to your former manner of life, lay aside the old self which is being corrupted in accordance with the lusts of deceit, that you may be renewed in the spirit of your mind, and put on the new self which is in the likeness of God has been created in righteousness and holiness and truth.

As a Christian, do you really know the difference between your old mind and your new mind?

Do you really know? Do you recognize what comes from the old mind and what comes from the new mind?

And do you struggle with Paul in Romans 7: "The good that I would I do not and that which I would not, I find I'm always doing! It's because I'm thinking wrong, I'm acting wrong! I'm thinking in the flesh, I'm acting in the flesh! I'm thinking in the spirit, I'm acting in the spirit!"

The battle is to think His thoughts after Him.

What does the OLD MIND do? With all its doubts, it's anxious, it has fearful thoughts. It's demonstrated in bitterness in the midst of difficulty. It betrays itself by being wrapped in material things. It is selfish.

It thinks the wrong thoughts, puts wrong interpretations on

actions of others. It demonstrates itself in hostility, guilt, depression and no sense of self-worth. That's the **OLD MIND**.

What's the **NEW MIND** going to look like?

John 3:30

He Christ must continually be increasing, and I must be decreasing.

It's demonstrated by **TRUST** in every situation, even though we don't understand.

It is looking for ways to be **BETTER** rather than **BITTER** in difficulty.

It is **THANKFUL** for all things in the midst of suffering.

It's **POSITIVE**, anticipating the ultimate glory.

If you're having a hard time recognizing the new mind, there it is written in bold, living color:

Philippians 4:8

Finally, brethren, whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure, whatsoever things are lovely, whatsoever things are of good report, if there be any virtue, if there be any praise, think on these things.

Here are a couple of more verses and then we'll wrap this up.

1 Peter 1:13

Gird up the loins of your mind.

If it's a battle in the mind then get ready for a battle. That's getting the flowing garments up and ready to fight with the mind.

2 Corinthians 10:5

Casting down imaginations and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God, and bring into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ.

Have you ever had thought and said, "I just don't have to think that thought." And just turn from it and think another thought?

Or have you ever memorized a passage of scripture and Satan throws a thought at you that just literally blows you away and you, with the passage of scripture, you just nail that thought right there? You stop it dead in its tracks.

Pamela Reeve has written some great books. One of them is called *Faith Is*. She wrote this little poem and shared it with a group of women when she was talking on the struggle of the mind:

Think through me thoughts of God,
My Father quiet me
Til in Thy holy presence hushed
I think Thy thoughts with Thee.
Think through me thoughts of God
And let my own thoughts be.
Silenced before eternal truth
As it is found in Thee.
Think through me thoughts of God,
That always, everywhere
The stream that through my being flows
May bless, not impair.

(source unknown)

How did that mind that was in Christ cause Christ to act?

These last verses is the great KENOSIS PASSAGE. Look at it now in view of the right mind.

If you say you've got the new mind going, then the new mind is going to start acting like this.

v. 6 who, existing in the form of God, looked not upon this being equal with God a prize to be grasped eagerly,

“who, existing in the form of God, looked not upon this being equal with God a prize to be grasped eagerly,”

He didn't look at that as something that he had to have.

2 Corinthians 8:9

...though he was rich, yet for our sakes, he became poor, that we through his poverty might be made rich.

v. 7 but emptied Himself, having taken the form of a servant, being made in the likeness of men.

“but emptied Himself, having taken the form of a servant, being made in the likeness of men.”

“he emptied Himself—that means He just dumped all of His prerogatives—“and He took the form of a servant, and He was made in the likeness of men.”

He came all the way down here. He took on human form.

He surrendered the prerogatives.

v. 8 And being found in outward appearance as a man, He humbled Himself, having become obedient to the point of death, even death of a cross.

“And being found in outward appearance as a man, He humbled Himself, having become obedient to the point of death, even death of a cross.”

That's about as far down as you can go.

He saw a need and He plunged into the human arena and played out the drama of 33 years of living a perfect life. Then He became sin for us all when He died on Calvary's cross.

What can we expect with a new mind? What have we got to look forward to?

v. 9 Therefore also God exalted Him to the highest place, and graciously bestowed upon Him the name which is above every name,

“Therefore also God exalted Him to the highest place, and graciously bestowed upon Him the name which is above every name,”

v. 10 in order that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those who are in heaven, and on earth, and under the earth,

“in order that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those who are in heaven, and on earth, and even under the earth,”

Satan's realm is going to have to acknowledge Jesus Christ as Lord.

v. 11 and that every tongue should confess (plainly and openly agree) that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.

“and every tongue should confess (plainly and openly agree) that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.”

We get the following lessons from this passage of scripture:

Lesson #1: We have learned of the power of encouragement, love, fellowship, sensitivity, and service.

Lesson #2: We are to be doing nothing according to self-seeking.

Lesson #3: We are to allow the mind of Christ our Savior to become our mind.

If He's going to make us like Jesus, He has to do something with our thoughts.

Lesson #4: Fellowship with the living Word and in the written Word will provide the framework for this mind.

That's the way we have a mind-change.

Lesson #5: Am I willing to empty myself of my rights and take the form of a servant?

Proverbs 3:5, 6

Trust in the Lord with all of your heart and lean not unto your own understanding In all your ways acknowledge

Him and He will direct your path.

Father, we come to You and we want the victory over the evil one. We want to focus on the person of the Lord Jesus and not our circumstances. May we find peace in the storm. To know that as we keep our eyes upon our victorious Savior, that would be our glorious victory in these moments. That death is not the end and only issues into eternity. As Paul reminded us, it's far better to be with You. To leave here and to go there. What joy will be ours as we enter Your presence as Your children. May You do a deep work in the lives of each of us. In Jesus' name we pray. Amen.

Copyright © 2022 by Bible Teaching Resources by Don Anderson Ministries. The author's teacher notes incorporate quoted, paraphrased and summarized material from a variety of sources, all of which have been appropriately credited to the best of our ability. Quotations particularly reside within the realm of fair use. It is the nature of teacher notes to contain references that may prove difficult to accurately attribute. Any use of material without proper citation is unintentional. Teacher notes have been compiled by Ronnie Marroquin.

A Practical Study of PHILIPPIANS

THE GOAL OF CHRISTIAN LIVING “Important Keys to Successful, Fulfilled Living”

GOAL NUMBER FOUR – THE MIND OF CHRIST – PHILIPPIANS 2:1-11

KEY VERSE 2:5

v. 1 If there is therefore any encouragement in Christ, if there is any solace afforded by love, if there is any fellowship of the Spirit, if there is any affection and sympathy,

v. 2 make full my joy in order that you may be thinking the same thing, having the same love, united in spirit, thinking the one thing,

v. 3 doing nothing from selfish ambition or from empty conceit, but with humility of mind regarding one another as excelling themselves;

v. 4 not looking out each one for his own interests, but also each one the interests of others.

v. 5 Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus,

v. 6 who, existing in the form of God, looked not upon this being equal with God a prize to be grasped eagerly,

v. 7 but emptied Himself, having taken the form of a servant, being made in the likeness of men.

v. 8 And being found in outward appearance as a man, He humbled Himself, having become obedient to the point of death, even death of a cross.

v. 9 Therefore also God exalted Him to the highest place, and graciously bestowed upon Him the name which is above every name,

v. 10 in order that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those who are in heaven, and on earth, and under the earth,

v. 11 and that every tongue should confess (plainly and openly agree) that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.

NOTES

QUESTIONS:

1. Read Philippians 2:1-11 and in your own words pull out the main thought of this passage.

2. What is Paul asking from his fellow believers in verse 1?

3. How are you supposed to treat others, according to verse 3?

4. What does Paul command in verse 5?

5. How can we fulfill this command in our daily lives?

6. What has Jesus done for us, according to verse 8? Why?

7. What did God, the Father, do for Jesus, according to verse 9?

8. What two things will everybody do some day, according to verses 10 and 11?

9. Which verse in the study has meant the most to you?

10. What lesson have you learned from this study?

LESSONS FROM THE PASSAGE:

What are some of the lessons we can learn from this particular study?

LESSON #1: We have learned of the power of encouragement, love, fellowship, sensitivity, and service.

LESSON #2: We are to be doing nothing according to self-seeking.

LESSON #3: We are to allow the mind of Christ our Savior to become our mind.

LESSON #4: Fellowship with the living Word and in the written Word will provide the framework for this mind.

LESSON #5: Am I willing to empty myself of my rights and take the form of a servant?